CITY OF BELLINGHAM
EXECUTIVE ORDER 2020-04
EXTENDING COVID-19
ECONOMIC RELIEF MEASURES

WHEREAS, on February 29, 2020, the Governor of the State of Washington proclaimed that a State of Emergency exists in all counties in the State of Washington due to the outbreak of novel coronavirus (COVID-19); and

WHEREAS, on March 16, 2020, the Governor issued an emergency proclamation aimed at limiting the spread of the disease by prohibiting: (1) the onsite consumption of food and/or beverages in public venues; (2) the operation of public venues in which people congregate for entertainment, social or recreational purposes; and (3) the operation of all retail stores, except pharmacies and grocery stores, unless the stores establish and implement appropriate social distancing and sanitation measures; and

WHEREAS, the restrictions included in the Governor's March 16 proclamation are appropriate for public health reasons, but have a significant adverse financial impact on businesses, nonprofit organizations and their employees, including loss of income and wages for a significant percentage of the local workforce; and

WHEREAS, on March 19, 2020, I issued Emergency Order 2020-01 to implement certain temporary economic relief measures, including the suspension of rent for small businesses and nonprofits that lease property from the City through May 31, 2020 and a moratorium on water shutoffs, late penalties and interest for City utility customers through June 1, 2020; and

WHEREAS, on March 23, 2020, the Governor issued an emergency "Stay Home – Stay Healthy" proclamation prohibiting all people in the State of Washington from leaving their homes and all non-essential businesses in Washington State from conducting business through April 6, 2020; and

WHEREAS, Governor Inslee subsequently extended his "Stay Home – Stay Healthy" proclamation through May 31, 2020; and

WHEREAS, Governor Inslee's extension of his "Stay Home – Stay Healthy" order is appropriate for public health reasons, but will extend and deepen the adverse financial impact already being felt by Bellingham residents, small businesses and nonprofits; and

WHEREAS, in order to promote the public health and welfare of our community during the COVID-19 health crisis, I deem it necessary and appropriate to extend for one (1) additional month the economic relief measures for City tenants and utility customers contained in Executive Order 2020-01 that are otherwise set to expire on May 31, 2020 and June 1, 2020; and

WHEREAS, extending the moratorium on rent for tenants of City property supports public health and welfare by encouraging the City's tenants to comply with the Governor's "Stay Home – Stay Healthy" proclamation by mitigating their financial burden during the COVID-19 health crisis; and

WHEREAS, extending the moratorium on rent is also in the City's business interest because it will help to ensure that the City's tenants will emerge from the health crisis as viable tenants, which not only supports the health and vibrancy of the City's downtown core, but also avoids the costs associated with tenant turnover; and

WHEREAS, extending the moratorium on water shut offs promotes the public health and welfare by ensuring that City utility customers will have a consistent supply of water for basic household needs, including hand washing to help prevent the spread of COVID-19.

NOW, THEREFORE, I, Seth Fleetwood, Mayor of the City of Bellingham, order as follows:

Section 1: Extension of Utility Relief.

The temporary moratorium on utility delinquency measures, including water shutoffs and late penalties and interest, as set forth in Section 2 of Executive Order 2020-01, is hereby extended through June 30, 2020.

Section 2: Extension of Rent Relief.

The temporary moratorium on rent for small businesses and nonprofits leasing City property, as set forth in Section 3 of Executive Order 2020-01, is hereby extended through June 30, 2020.

Dated this 7th day of May, 2020.

Mayor Seth Fleetwood

Attest:

Finance Director

Approved as to Form:

Office of the City Attorney